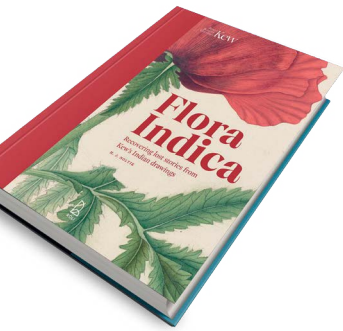
whole, collections reassembled and individual artists reunited with their works. "It's a combination of detective work, botany, art history, archive work, translations...it all comes together," he says. Reddy underlines the importance of this: "There's nobody who would be able




**FLORA INDICA**
Recovering Lost Stories From Kew's Indian Drawings
*By Henry Noltie*
ROLI BOOKS
**₹2,495; 224** pages

to do that with Indian botanical art. We call it 'Henry's method'."

*Flora Indica* is a superb exhibition, and one that they hope will travel to India. Working around the financial, logistical and conservation constraints, they intend to have the works printed in India as high quality giclée facsimiles. This, for them, is not simply an artistic ambition, but a moral and political one: an act of restorative justice, decolonialising botanical art history and going some way to finally giving these Indian artists—and their beloved plants—their due. ■

***—Anita Roy***



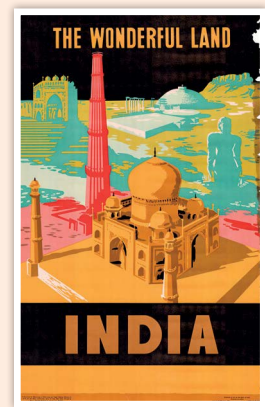

EXHIBITION ▶

# Travel Dreams, Hand-Drawn

**AN EXHIBITION AT GURUGRAM'S HERITAGE TRANSPORT MUSEUM TRACES HOW HAND-DRAWN POSTERS SHAPED INDIA'S TRAVEL IMAGINATION**

**Decades before social media gave us the travel bug, India learned to dream of distant places through posters pasted at railway stations, airline offices and shipping terminals. An exhibition at Gurugram's Heritage Transport Museum, titled *Posters That Moved India*, celebrates those forgotten visuals.**

**Drawn from founder Tarun Thakral's personal collection, it traces how travel in India was once imagined, marketed and sold—through hand-drawn railway posters, early aviation imagery, shipping advertisements and tourism promotions from the 1930s to the 1970s. "I am very fascinated by posters on paper," says Thakral, pointing to their individuality. "Artists used to paint these by hand, with illustrations and typography, before they were converted into posters."**




**MANY POSTERS PROMOTED RAIL TRAVEL, WHILE OTHERS HIGHLIGHTED PILGRIM ROUTES AND TEMPLES**

**Many works promoted rail travel, while others highlighted temples, pilgrimage routes and regional landmarks. Some posters, created for foreign audiences, adopted an Art Deco aesthetic, selling India through romanticised nightscapes or stylised street scenes. Yet others brought far-flung places like Europe into the Indian imagination, offering glimpses of ocean liners and modern lifestyles.**

**Air India's iconic advertising forms a key section here. Under advertising chief Bobby Kooka, the airline pioneered humour-led visual storytelling through its Maharaja mascot.**

**After its run at the museum until February 28, Thakral plans to take the exhibition to other cities. For now, it sits naturally within the larger ethos of the Heritage Transport Museum, India's first transport museum. It was built, Thakral says, to be "a visitor-centric attraction", where "everything is a story and a conversation piece", With *Posters That Moved India*, that philosophy finds one of its most evocative expressions yet—using fragile paper and forgotten ink to show how a country once learned to imagine movement, modernity and the promise of elsewhere. ■**

***—Satarupa Paul***